INDIA'S SMART CITIES

Unlocking a Sustainable Tomorrow for the World Today!



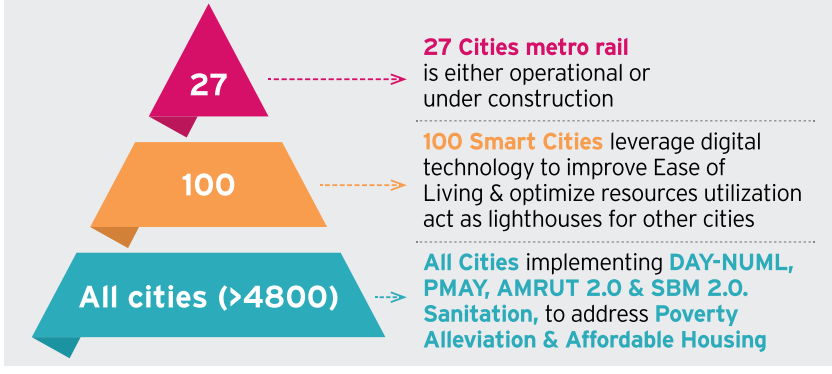
KUNAL KUMAR
JOINT SECRETARY, MOHUA

GLOBAL SNAPSHOT

Over half of global population lives in urban areas. Of the urban growth projected upto 2050, Asia and Africa will contribute 90%. India, China, and Nigeria are expected to account for 35% of this growth. India will add approximately 500 million people to its urban population by 2050. Cities' vulnerability to climate change, disasters, and conflicts increases due to concentrated people and assets. Smart city development focuses on planning and management for growth, prosperity, and sustainability.

INDIA'S MULTIPRONGED APPROACH

India's cities are at different stages of development. There is a lot of heterogeneity in cultures, contexts, legal frameworks, and achievements. Therefore, a three-level strategy, as highlighted below has been followed by the Government of India:



MoHUA strategy

WHAT DO WE MEAN BY SMART CITIES?

Smart cities in common parlance are understood to be cities that use digital technologies for improving quality of lives of their citizens. However, this definition misses out on other important aspects. The concept of Smart Cities in the Indian context is woven around 6 mantras, the first being citizen at the core. The second core principle is achieving more from Less. Thirdly, the Mission champions cooperative and competitive federalism. The fourth mantra is innovation, integration and sustainability. The fifth, technology is one of the means, not the only means and certainly not the goal of smart city development. And 6th very importantly is inclusiveness.

MISSION STRATEGY

Broadly, the Mission has a two-fold strategy - Area Based development and Pan City development. It is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme with a Central allocation of 48,000 crore. Emphasis has been given on the participation of private sector through Public Private Partnerships (PPPs). Citizens' aspirations are captured in the Smart City Proposals (SCPs) prepared by the cities. Implementation of SCM at the city level is done by a Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) created for the purpose. 100 cities have been selected through a 2-stage national competition.

HOW HAS THE SMART CITIES MISSION EVOLVED?

100 Smart Cities were selected from 2016 to 2018, receiving over ₹ 75,000 crore in grants, with over 90% used. 6,000 projects completed, 2000 under implementation.

TECHNOLOGY AS A MEANS, AND NOT THE END

All Smart Cities have an Integrated Command and Control Centre, integrating digital technologies for real-time monitoring and decision-making. Results include improved traffic sense, reduced garbage and littering, improved air quality, flood sensors, emergency callboxes, and free Wi-Fi hotspots. These measures have led to significant improvements in city life.

IMPACT ON QUALITY OF LIFE AND ECONOMY

Smart cities' projects are not only promoting sustainable development but also helping create vibrant, inclusive, healthy and collaborative cities. The Mission promotes mixed land-use in area-based developments as proximity and density reduce per capita costs of providing infrastructure and services, while creating knowledge spillovers and specialization that hugely enhance urban productivity.

INNOVATION AS KEY DRIVER

Smart Cities make use of cutting-edge technology across areas and sectors to enhance ease of living for their citizens. The Mission has championed the City Innovation Exchange platform, wherein more than 700 startups are closely engaging with the 100 smart cities, thereby increasing their visibility and increasing procurement of their innovative goods and services.

IMPACT ON SUSTAINABILITY

Smart Cities have proposed investments to ensure at least 10% of the city's energy requirement coming from Solar Energy. Diu has become the first city to completely switch over to solar power during the daytime. Many other cities have executed projects on renewable energy including solar and wind energy. Close to 100 MW of solar energy capacity have been installed, mostly for captive use for city establishments and service infrastructure.

CITY CHALLENGES: NURTURING NEW AVENUES IN URBAN DEVELOPMENT

The **Nurturing Neighborhoods Challenge** has enabled Indian cities adopt an early childhood lens in designing neighbourhood-level improvements that promote the health and well-being of young children and their caregivers. The **India Cycles4Change Challenge** is an initiative to inspire and support smart cities to implement cycling-friendly initiatives and build city-scale cycling infrastructure. The **Streets for People Challenge** is an initiative to inspire creation of walkable cities through quick, low cost measures. The **EatSmart Cities challenge** promotes smart nutrition and healthy food practices while the **Transport4All Challenge** is fostering adoption of public transport and alleviation of commuter grievances through startup driven innovative solutions. The Mission has brought about a **placemaking revolution** in our cities as well.

WAY FORWARD: CHALLENGES AND OPPORTUNITIES

Smart cities face challenges in urban finance, requiring scaling up innovative financing models like municipal bonds and value capture, and standardization to enhance their development. Cities must develop systemic mechanisms to engage citizens throughout development, and the effectiveness of technology deployment can improve with the integration of more services.

Smart Cities are incubators for New Urban India, fostering collective urban renaissance. They serve as innovation laboratories, preparing the nation for a new urban revolution.